

MUSIC FOR YOUR EARS

Buying a hi-fi set of speakers can burn a hole in your pocket, these are not only expensive but extremely bulky at times. A good pair of earphones wouldn't leave you short on cash but are also the style statement when it comes to the cool factor. Here's an in-depth write up: nyti.ms/twOTS8

ANDROID 4.0 REVIEWED

The new update for the Android system seems to be promising for its devices, especially the uniform experience that it would offer across phones and tablets. Apart from this a totally redesigned user interface would offer something new and fresh to the Android customer. Here's a first look at the new OS: bit.ly/vze6Wc

CELLPHONE BATTLES

What happens when IP addresses belonging to a particular brand post comments in favour of its product? That's what happened with the Lumia 800 review where both Microsoft and Nokia posted favourable comments on a shallow write up that was merely based on the phone specifications. bit.ly/rA4fzG

THINGS THAT GO BEHIND GAMES

Game making is an uphill task with mammoth amounts of art development, hours of sound recording and story writing and narration that is at par with top Hollywood flicks. Here's a look under the hood of the best game engine and what powers them. bit.ly/sB2b5t

x86 CPUs in 2012: What's ahead for Intel and AMD

- By Joel Hruska



Copyright © 2011
Ziff Davis Publishing
Holdings Inc.

2012 is a major year for both Intel and AMD. For Chipzilla, it's showtime for Atom and a suite of new high-end mobile products. AMD will also try to capitalize on the mobile momentum it built through 2011 while simultaneously re-positioning itself and dealing with product delays.

Intel: Smartphones and ultrabooks

Intel will spend 2012 primarily focused on two, relatively new mobile computing sectors: smartphones and ultrabooks. 2012 will likely be the year Atom finally picks up design wins and starts shipping in handsets. Even if it doesn't do much volume, this is Intel's foot-in-the-door year; the company's stated goal is to launch a design that's competitive with ARM products, both in terms of performance and power consumption. If it can manage that, other concerns, like application compatibility, will come into line as the year progresses.

The other major focus of the year is ultrabooks. Intel has set an ambitious sales target of 40% by the end of the year and is investing in both component research and marketing funds for the new systems. Despite these factors, the company's overall risk is low. If ultrabooks take off, Intel wins credit for driving innovation and helping to launch a new form factor.

The graphic is a dark blue rounded rectangle. On the left, under the heading 'MEDIA', is an image of a laptop displaying a video player. In the center, under 'Intel® Quick Sync Video TECHNOLOGY', is an 'Intel® WiDi Wireless Display' logo showing a laptop and a monitor connected by a signal. On the right, under 'Intel® Insider™', is a grid of logos for various services: 24/7, Warner Bros., Disney, IMAGE CHANNEL, FOX NOW, hungama, HBO, CinemaNow, SONIC, 20th Century Fox, and UTV. At the bottom, the text reads 'Ultrabook™ devices deliver outstanding media experiences' with the Intel logo below it.

If ultrabooks don't gain traction in the mass market, Intel still has a suite of new low-power Ivy Bridge chips plus its investments in thinner form factors and lighter parts. All of these elements are useful in the long term, even if they aren't deployed simultaneously in the company's current vision of an ultrabook. OEMs could, for example, combine low-TDP and thinner components with a larger battery. Meanwhile, customers are still going to be buying plenty of Intel-powered desktops and laptops.

As for tablets, x86-powered Android flavors will exist, but it won't be a particularly large market segment. This has less to do with Atom's ability to scale into a tablet and is more the result of other market factors. The only signs of life in that market are at the lower end, where the Kindle Fire and Nook Tablet are doing fairly well. Neither product is a good

fit for Intel at this point, if only because they target rock-bottom price points that Santa Clara probably doesn't want to match.

In servers, desktops, and traditional laptops, 2012 will be the year of performance-per-watt. While Ivy Bridge's integrated GPU is said to be much faster than Sandy Bridge's, the CPU is only modestly faster. The big talking points across Intel's product lines will be delivering improved efficiency. This will pass muster with virtually everyone because the shift towards laptops and other mobile devices means total battery life is now part of virtually any performance metric.

The relatively small handful of buyers concerned with speed above all other factors won't find a lot to crow about in 2012. Ivy Bridge's overclocking headroom probably won't be much better than SB's (at least, not on air cooling). Multi-threaded performance